



Heated COVID Face Mask

Researchers have designed a reusable, heated face mask which inactivates viruses. <http://digit.in/nov20-19>



COVID-19 can relieve pain

Research proves that the neuropilin-1 receptor present in SARS-CoV-2 promotes pain relief. <http://digit.in/nov20-20>

FIGHTING THE PANDEMIC

PART III

The research directions to stop the spread of the novel coronavirus

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here are now 213 vaccines in development (as against 212 last month) with 37 in clinical trials.

Only a handful of these vaccines are eventually going to get approval for widespread production and distribution. Research around the world continues at a furtive pace, for better understanding the virus, figuring out ways to contain its spread, finding new techniques for scaling up production of masks and PPE kits and developing approaches for

decontamination of protective gear for reuse. A lot of the recent research focuses on the effects of the virus on people, not in a strictly medical sense, but in a psychological and social manner. Here is a look at some of the latest research on the novel coronavirus, SARS-CoV-2, and the disease it causes, COVID-19.

UNDERSTANDING THE HUMANS

When addressing a pandemic, it is important to understand how humans behave during an outbreak, as much as it is necessary to understand the virus itself. The beliefs held by antivaxxers and antimaskers can be called “cultural pathogens”, the bad variants of memes that can spread between people faster than the virus itself. Those people who just do not listen to healthcare workers, policy guidelines from the government, or scientists, pose a major threat to public health. So who are these people listening to then? They are forming their views based on the opinions of politicians, which subse-

quently “informs” their behavior as well. The unpredictability of human behavior makes it difficult to predict the course of the pandemic.

Antimaskers and antivaxxers are not only getting increasingly vocal, but also getting increasingly militant, which is becoming a major problem around the world. According to researchers from the University of Michigan, the coverage of the pandemic in newspapers is at least as politically charged and polarising as the coverage on climate change. The attitudes towards the pandemic were shaped by the early coverage of the outbreak, a finding based on analysis of the news from March to May 2020. The reason for this was that politicians were given as much importance as the scientists by the news channels, and the news papers went ahead and actually provided more coverage to the politicians instead of the scientists. Politicisation here is the degree to which politicians are mentioned in relation to the coverage, and the polarisation is the extent to which political actors manage to vary the discussion. In newspapers, the polarisation spiked in March 2020, and continued to be elevated since